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Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman recently presented her seventh Union Budget. This was the first Budget of the third term of the Prime Minister Narendra Modi-led NDA government and people were looking for cues to the dispensation's fiscal road map for the next five years. The Budget has focussed on employment and fiscal consolidation, while charting a path towards development. In an exclusive interview with *Rahul Kanwal*, News Director of India Today and Aaj Tak and Executive Director of *Business Today*, *Sourav Majumdar*, Editor of *Business Today*, and BTTV Managing Editor *Siddharth Zarabi*, she talks about financial incentives to employers, taxes, the agriculture sector, and more. Edited excerpts:

RAHUL KANWAL: How confident are you that the employment-linked incentives (ELI) you have offered to industry will trigger net incremental new job creation?

A: Yes, they will. Because even as we are telling them (industry) to benefit from the incentives that we are giving, we are giving monthly EPFO payments [and] one month's salary up to ₹15,000 irrespective of the salary for which the person is recruited. And very clearly saying it has to be a new addition to the job. And that new addition will have to be enrolled into the EPFO... Second, the employer is also incentivised in this process, when he brings in new people... who's a fresher, meaning first-time jobseeker. And the second scheme is you can bring in anybody, but also include the newcomers... And EPFO has unique numbers, so no replication can happen. We are confident that it is possible for us to monitor it.

RK: And your response to the political charge that before the poll results, your government was supposedly in denial about the enormity of the job crisis? Also, some say that a few of these ideas like ELI and the apprenticeship/internship programme are lifted from the Congress's manifesto...

A: If I say this, it might be too late for you to accept that I'm telling the truth, but it is all in the records... Since 2014, [for] every proposal that went to the cabinet, the PM would say, 'You've given me the justification for the proposal to come to the cabinet. What I want you to give additionally, is to tell me how many direct and indirect jobs will this create?' And I think by 2016, all of us got into the groove... we had to go back and work out how many jobs [a proposal] would create... Second, for the positions that were lying unfilled in the government... they were filled up every month through *rozgar melas* (employment fairs) between November 2022 and December 2023. If we didn't take jobs and the necessity of filling up the posts seriously, why would we do this? If we didn't think jobs were an important element of the economy, why would our cabinet notes have to have a section talking about what would be the impact on jobs?

And to be told, 'you've copied it from Congress's manifesto,' I want to say it's a very convenient and lazy argument to put forward... For instance, they

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“There is a reset happening in industry. They are looking at Industry 4.0 seriously. A lot of them are trying to reset their own businesses so that productivity gains can be accrued to them”

said they would give apprenticeship as a right. And that they would give ₹1,000, I think, in their manifesto. But we gave it for people so that they will be there [in the job] for one year, and paid every month by the central government and the company... In the EPFO-linked scheme, we've also said that you (employer) take all the incentives, but if you remove the person, you refund the amount.